How do reptiles survive?

Reptiles survive by using special body features and behaviours to control their temperature, find food, and hide from danger.

1. Warming Up and Cooling Down

- **Cold-Blooded (Ectothermic):** Reptiles cannot make their own body heat. They use the environment to stay warm or cool.
- **Sunbathing:** In the morning, lizards and snakes lie out on warm rocks to bake in the sun so they have energy to move.
- **Finding Shade or Burrows:** When they get too hot, they scurry under rocks, climb into shady trees, or dig underground burrows.
- **Hibernation and Emotion:** When winter gets too cold, many reptiles go to sleep in a deep rest called **hibernation** . Some hot-weather reptiles rest during dry, hot summers in a process called **estivation** .

2. Saving Water with Scales

- **Dry, Scaly Skin:** Unlike frogs, reptiles have tough, dry skin covered in scales or hard plates. This stops water from evaporating out of their bodies so they can live in hot, dry deserts.
- **Shedding Skin:** As a reptile grows, it peels off its old skin in one piece or large patches to reveal fresh scales underneath.

3. Finding Food & Low Energy

- **Carnivores and Herbivores:** Most reptiles are meat-eaters (carnivores) that hunt insects, mice, or fish. Some, like tortoises and certain iguanas, munch on plants and flowers.
- **Slow Metabolism:** Because they do not waste energy trying to warm themselves from the inside, reptiles need much less food than mammals do. A large crocodile can go for months on a single large meal.
- **Swallowing Rocks:** Plant-eating reptiles often swallow small pebbles (called gastroliths) that bounce around in their tummies to grind up tough leaves.

4. Hiding and Defending Themselves

- **Camouflage:** Many reptiles blend right into green leaves, brown dirt, or yellow sand so enemies cannot see them.
- **Dropping Tails:** If a predator grabs a lizard by the tail, the tail can pop right off and wiggle on the ground to distract the enemy while the lizard dashes away to safety.
- **Shells and Hissing:** Turtles pull their heads and legs inside hard, protective shells. Other reptiles hiss loudly, puff up their bodies, or shake a rattle (like a rattlesnake) to warn bad guys to stay away.

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